

Swing Low Sweet Chariot

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My mother's grandfather died before I was born. He was an executive at Standard Oil. He had their stately three-story Tudor-style home built during the height of The Great Depression on the shore of a medium-sized lake with a small boat dock.¹⁰ Behind the boat dock was a large empty field. Finally, the house sat atop a hill. From the front, it appeared to be a stately two-story home. From the rear, you could see that it was a three-story home with a two-car garage on the bottom level.

THE HOUSE

We always entered through the side entrance which took you through the garden. Then, you entered through a pair of French doors into a vestibule. Immediately to your left was an open archway into the great hall. I distinctly remember the dark-stained cypress columns that ran across the ceiling. Despite my recollection being a child's memory, I know that my grandfather was six feet tall and the ceiling was easily twice his height. So it's safe to say that the ceiling was between 12 and 15 feet high.¹¹

To give a sense of scale, there was a baby grand piano in a corner of the room that might easily be overlooked. I recall asking why the keys were

¹⁰ Think canoe

¹¹ The ceiling height is integral to climate control in a home in the American south without HVAC.

yellow and was told that it was because they were old ivory. I also recall asking my mother why the hunter green velvet curtains were too long for the windows. They were piled up on the ground. She told me, “That was just the style back then.” Later, I learned that it was a cultural signal of opulence and wealth to have enough money to “waste” on superfluous fabric.

Naturally, the house was furnished exclusively in Elizabethan and Edwardian antique furniture. I recall a red crushed velvet loveseat positioned in front of a pair of glass French doors that led out to the same garden we walked through to enter the house. The actual main entrance was on the opposite wall. But oddly, I don’t recall anyone ever using it.

On the wall adjacent to where we entered the great hall was a set of double doors that led into the dining room. It was actually uncharacteristically small compared to the hall that preceded it. The table sat eight people¹² with ample space for servers to move about. The only other furniture in the room was a China cabinet.¹³ One odd memory I have of eating in that room was that the silverware was actually made of pewter and it tasted weird. No, there was no one in the corner pulling a rope to move a fan over the table! But your instinct isn’t very far off...

When you entered the dining room from the great hall, if you looked immediately to your right, there was a saloon door that swung on a

¹² In all likelihood, it had multiple leaves and expanded to seat 12, but I just don’t specifically remember that.

¹³ Logical placement

spring mechanism leading into a small breakfast area and then the kitchen.¹⁴ The breakfast area was just a booth with two high-backed wooden bench seats on either side. It could accommodate four people who liked each other.

The kitchen featured a large black iron natural gas stove, lots of counter space and cabinetry, a large sink, and a refrigerator. A door off to the side led into a large walk-in pantry. Another door on the other side of the room led to another outdoor patio seating area. While that could describe a nice home today, there was one tiny difference. If you looked up near the ceiling, there were a series of bells mounted to the wall. Beneath each bell was the name of a room. Within each room of the house was a button that caused a corresponding bell to ring.

Returning to the breakfast area, there was an archway leading out to the vestibule where we first entered the house. On the right was the archway that led back into the great hall. On the opposite wall were the French doors we first entered through. On the left was a flight of just three stairs that led to a hallway that provided access to the bedrooms and bathrooms. At the very end of that hallway was a set of stairs. Going down dropped you in the garage and going up just brought you into a locked door. I was never permitted past that door. As a child, I didn't understand this, but I also really didn't care. As an adult, I know precisely what was beyond that door.¹⁵

It's worth noting that the house did not contain a television. My great-grandmother did own an AM radio that she likely acquired after her

¹⁴ Logical placement

¹⁵ It was the servants' living quarters

husband's death. Otherwise, the home was designed only for reading and socializing. Any music had to be performed live, hence the piano.

Moving into the back yard, I remember a large iron bell stood atop the hill between the house and the field. This was not a little decorative dinner bell. Think more along the lines of the Liberty Bell. It was a massive iron bell suspended in an equally substantial iron frame, with an armature connected to a rope and a heavy iron striker hanging inside. To ring it, you pulled the rope hard enough to swing the bell against the striker. As a small child, I had to use my entire body weight to make it ring.



“Close enough” AI rendering of said bell

I asked what the bell was for and was told that it was used to call the slaves in from the field when it was time to eat. But that was many

years ago.¹⁶ Being kids, my cousins and I would spend time rolling down the hill, which was apparently great fun at the time. Out of either a sense of irony or simple convenience, one of our parents would ring the bell to let us know it was time for lunch.¹⁷

THE PERMANENT RESIDENTS

Lunch was served by the ladies who ran the house. I noted that they were both middle-aged black women. It just sort of stood out since everyone else was white. I recall them being very warm and kind people that I was quite fond of. It's worth noting that there wasn't a hint of racism mentioned by anyone in this house.¹⁸

I noticed that the adults got very nervous about answering my questions about the ladies. I was told that they were *servants* who lived in the house full-time. Their parents and grandparents had also served in the house.

Years later, my father explained to me that those women were born in the house and no one had bothered to tell the social security administration of their existence. Their grandparents were either moved into the house from a prior residence or were purchased from another estate; no one was entirely certain. But it was understood that

¹⁶ To be clear, there was no farming going on in my lifetime.

¹⁷ Just to assuage your disbelief, this house still stands today. It is located at 3115 Dalrymple Dr. in Baton Rouge, Louisiana. It is not owned by family any longer and it no longer contains slaves. Please respect the current owners' privacy.

¹⁸ This does not mean that racism did not exist, only that it was impolite to verbalize.

these women were the last generation of a lineage that could be traced directly to chattel slavery.¹⁹

Despite how bad that undoubtedly sounds to a modern reader, it's worth noting that not only were they not restrained in any way but were even permitted the use of the car to go grocery shopping.²⁰ So, they were in no way being held against their will.²¹

THE END

My great-grandmother died in 1986 when I was eight years old. I still remember watching the servants sitting in the last pew at the back of the church weeping much more fiercely than anyone else at her funeral.

I spoke with one of them afterward as my grandfather was clearing them out and preparing the estate to be sold. They explained to me that they were scared of life outside the house. As it was, they were living in a beautiful home, having their every need provided, and the work was really not very hard. Now they had to find jobs,²² likely as

¹⁹ It's OK if you need to set the book down and take a break.

²⁰ My great-grandmother had never gotten a driver's license because she always had a driver to take her anywhere she wanted to go.

²¹ You could argue that they were institutionally restrained, but who isn't? Think about it.

²² The reason I know that the women didn't have social security numbers is because I recall my parents discussing that they were applying to have the women be assigned numbers. How the SSA responded to that application, I cannot say. But I'd be willing to bet it wasn't the first time that this has happened.

maids at a cheap hotel, deal with finances, and live in a dangerous low-income neighborhood. *They had nothing to be happy about.*

THE PHILOSOPHICAL PIVOT

The point of the story isn't that slavery is a good thing. The reality is that slavery didn't end with The Emancipation Proclamation. In fact, one could argue that it just changed forms. What I witnessed was the very tail end of a very specific kind of slavery that is likely extinct as of the publication of this story.²³ But it was replaced with wage slavery, which seems different in theory, but is often difficult to distinguish in practice.

2026 UPDATE

But it gets worse: That last paragraph was written 25 years ago. Modern reality contains a far darker statistic. Forget the wage slavery argument. Let's just consider actual slavery. Fact: There are more people enslaved today than there were at the very height of American slavery.²⁴ Living in Austin, Texas, I see them at least weekly.²⁵ While people seem to care more about abolishing slavery today, they seem to be equally as ineffective at actually doing so.

²³ Mostly due to a lack of will to continue it combined with the obvious logistical problem of trying to sell property with people living in it.

²⁴ The 1860 U.S. Census counted 3,953,760 enslaved people at the eve of the Civil War. The ILO estimates 27.6 million people in forced labor in 2021, or 49.6 million in "modern slavery" when forced marriage is included.

²⁵ I'm talking about human trafficking. Sex trafficking, specifically. The only reason you don't see it is because you don't know what to look for.

The following are examples of human trafficking:

- Pimps & escort services
- Maid services that charge \$30 to clean your whole house
- Day labor

If you have ever been excited about getting a good deal on having another person perform labor for you, then you have most likely materially supported human trafficking.²⁶

The old cast iron bells are still ringing; they have just changed frequencies.

²⁶ It's OK. I've done it too. I didn't know any better at the time. Neither did you. But we both know better now.